

Finger Loading Readiness Self-Screen

A 4-gate pre-training screen · Written by David McWeeny, MSc Kinesiology, CSEP-CPT

Clinical scope & disclaimer

This is an educational self-screen, not a diagnosis or a substitute for individual medical advice. It is designed for adult climbers considering structured hangboard loading. It is **not** designed for climbers under about 16, for anyone with under roughly a year of consistent climbing, or for a finger that is currently painful, swollen, or recently injured. **Any pop, swelling, bowstringing, or pain that persists beyond 48 hours means stop and see a physiotherapist or sports physician before loading.** You train at your own risk.

The 4 core readiness gates

Work through each gate honestly. Note whether your answer is a **flag** (left column below) before you total your result on page 2.

Gate	What to self-check	Flag if...
1. Active joint pathology / capsular tenderness	Press gently around each finger joint and the base of each finger. Compare left to right. Note any joint that is swollen, warm, stiff on waking, or tender to press.	Any joint swelling, warmth, morning stiffness, or focal tenderness — or a known unresolved pulley/joint injury.
2. Climbing age / tissue history	How long have you climbed consistently? Tendon and pulley tissue adapts slowly and lags behind muscle and nervous system.	Under ~1 year of consistent climbing, under age ~16, or a finger injury in the last 3 months.
3. Unweighted 10s passive & half-crimp tolerances	On a 20 mm edge at bodyweight, hold a 10-second open-hand (passive) hang, rest, then a 10-second half-crimp. Rate discomfort 0–10 during and for 24 h after.	Cannot hold 10 s at bodyweight, discomfort above ~3/10, or soreness that climbs over the next 24 h.
4. Acute:chronic workload ratio (ACWR)	Compare this week's climbing + finger load (acute) with your rolling 4-week average (chronic). A ratio near 0.8–1.3 is a steadier zone; spikes raise risk.	This week is a sharp spike over your 4-week average (ratio well above ~1.3), or you are returning from a long layoff.

The pain-monitoring rule used throughout: loading is acceptable at up to about **3/10 discomfort that settles within 24 hours** and does not trend upward week to week. Never train through sharp pain.

Scoring: decision matrix & routing

Take your **most cautious** result — one red flag routes you to red, regardless of the other gates.

Result	What it means	Route to
RED	Any Gate 1 flag, an unresolved injury, or pain above ~3/10 that does not settle in 24 h.	Clinical referral. See a physiotherapist or sports physician before any loading. This screen stops here.
AMBER	No red flags, but limited climbing age, a recent (resolved) niggle, or borderline tolerances.	Connective-tissue capacity. Build with submaximal repeaters / density work first; re-screen in 4–6 weeks before adding high force.
GREEN	No flags, ~2+ years climbing, pain-free tolerances, steady workload.	High-force neural recruitment. You are a reasonable candidate for max hangs , progressed conservatively with the gates in place.

Session warm-up protocol

- 1 **Raise (3–5 min):** easy cardio or brisk movement until hands are warm.
- 2 **Mobilise:** wrist circles, finger flexion/extension, light band work for wrist extensors.
- 3 **Pulse-raise on rock/board:** 5–10 min of easy climbing on big holds, no crimping.
- 4 **Ramp hangs:** 3–4 progressively firmer sub-maximal hangs on a large edge, resting fully, until the grip you will train feels ready — never straight into a max effort cold.

Next steps

- **Amber?** Start with the free guide on the difference between the two tools: *Max Hangs vs. Repeaters*.
- **Green?** Follow the free *8-Week Finger Strength Block*, and load it with *How Much Weight to Add to Hangboard Hangs*.
- Re-run this screen before each new training block, and any time you return from a layoff.
- Read the free articles at thecuriousclimber.github.io/curiousclimber — or, when you want the block written out session by session, see the *Contact Strength & Finger Power* guide.

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